Lacrimabili Statu

Pius X · 1912-06-07 · English

ENCYCLICAL OF HIS HOLINESS PIUS X.,
BY DIVINE PROVIDENCE POPE,
ON THE CONDITION OF THE INDIANS, '

To THE Archbishops and Bishops of Latin America.

PIUS X. POPE.

Venerable Brothers, Health and the Apostolic Benediction:

EEPLY moved by the pitiful state of the Indians of South

America, our illustrious predecessor, Benedict XIV., earnestly

pleaded for them, as you know, in his letter Immensa Pas- torutn, dated December 22, 1741 ; and as we have to deplore almost the very things which he deplored when he wrote, therefore do we hasten to remind you of that letter of his. Therein indeed does Benedict complain, amongst other things, that although the Holy See had long done a great deal to alleviate their sad lot, neverthe- less there were even then "men who as it were wholly unmindful of the feelings of charity infused into our hearts by the Holy Ghost, presume not only in the case of the Indians who are deprived of the light of faith, but even of those who have been bathed in the sacred laver of regeneration, either to make them slaves, or to sell them as slaves to others, or to plunder them of their pos- sessions, or to act towards them with such inhumanity as to hinder them utterly from embracing the faith of Christ, or confirm them the more in their hatred toward it."

The worst of these indignities, namely, slavery properly so called, was, by the favor of the merciful God, soon afterwards abolished; and towards its public abolition in Brazil and in other regions the maternal entreaties of the Church made to the distinguished men who governed those States contributed much. Gratefully do we acknowledge that their designs would have led to much better results had not difficulties many and g^eat, both of locality and circumstance, confronted them. Although something then has been done for the Indians, yet what still remains to be done is much greater. Indeed, when we consider the crimes and misdeeds which still are commonly done against them, our mind is stricken with horror and we feel the deepest pity for that unhappy race. What, indeed, is so cruel and so barbarous as, for reasons often trivial and not rarely for the mere pleasure of inflicting torture, to put men to death by scourging or with red-hot irons; or, suddenly attacking them, to massacre them, killing hundreds and thousands of them together; or to sadc towns and villages, slaughtering the

natives, of whom within these past few years some tribes have, we learn, been almost exterminated ? To render minds thus savage, the greed of gain certainly contributes in large measure, but the very nature of the climate and the situation of those regions also contribute not a little thereto. For those regions possess a torrid climate, which infects the blood with a certain languor and enfeebles strength of character; and it easily happens that if some persons who are not of depraved morals betake themselves thither, finding themselves strangers to every religious practice, far from the vigi- lance of the State and almost deprived of civil society, they begin in a short time to grow depraved, and, little by little, all restraint^ of duty and of law being removed, they plunge into all the excesses of vice. Nor do they spare the weakness of sex or age; indeed one is ashamed to record the crimes and misdeeds which they perpetrate, acquiring women and children and trafficking in them, so that they may be said with truth to have surpassed the worst examples of pagan depravity.

In truth, when rumors of this kind reached us, we hesitated for some time to give credit to such atrocities, so incredible did they appear to us. But having been fully informed by many witnesses, to wit, by the greater number of you, venerable brothers, by the Delegates of the Apostolic See, by the missionaries and by other persons wholly trustworthy, we can no longer lawfully doubt that these things are true.

Resolved, therefore, for a long time past to strive, as far as in us lies, to repair evils so great, we beg of God, with humble and suppliant entreaties, that He may benignantly indicate to us some suitable means of remedying them. He, who is the most loving Creator and Redeemer of all men, as He has inspired us to labor for the salvation of the Indians, will certainly supply us with the means of effecting our purpose. Meanwhile, however, it affords us the greatest consolation to know that the rulers of those republics are endeavoring by every means to rid their States of this stain and of this disgrace ; which endeavor of theirs we cannot too highly approve and praise. Yet in those regions, distant as they are from the

seats of government, remote and for the most part inaccessible, either through the craft of evildoers who opportunely cross the frontier, or through the apathy and perfidy of the officials, these efforts of the civil authorities oftentimes avail little, and not un- frequently fail altogether. But if to the efforts of the State were united those of the Qiurch, the desired results world be more abundant.

To you, therefore, venerable brothers, before all others we appeal to devote special thought and care to this cause, which is eminently

worthy of your pastoral office and ministry. And leaving other things to your solicitude and zeal, before all else we earnestly exhort you to foster diligently all those institutions in your dioceses which are intended for the well-being of the Indians and to take steps to establish such others as may appear useful for the same purpose. You will also employ all diligence in impressing upon the faithful their sacred duty of assisting the missions to the natives, who were the first to inhabit American territory. Make known to them that in two ways they ought to aid this enterprise, to wit, by collecting offerings and by the assistance of their prayers ; and that not only religion, but also the fatherland itself demands this at their hands. And you, wherever proper moral education is carried on, that is to say, in the seminaries, in institutions for the young, in schools for girls, and above all in the churches, take care that there be no flagging in the inculcation and preaching of Christian charity, which regards all men as brethren, without distinction of nation or color, and which is to be shown not only by words, but by deeds. In like manner, no opportunity which presents itself of showing what dishonor is brought upon the Qiristian name by the reprehensible deeds which we have here denounced, should be allowed to pass.

As regards ourselves, as we reasonably cherish good hopes of the consent and favor of the public authorities, it shall be our principal care to extend, in these regions so vast, the field of apostolic enterprise, by instituting further missionary stations in which the Indians will find a refuge and a place of safety. Indeed, the Catholic Church has never lacked apostolic men who, urged by the charity of Jesus Christ, were not ready and willing to give even life itself for their brethren. And even to-day, when so many are averse to the faith, or renounce it, zeal for spreading the Gospel amongst the barbarians has not only not grown faint amongst persons of either grade of the clergy and amongst holy nuns, but is still in- creasing and diiJuses itself more widely through the power of the Holy Spirit, Who, according to the necessities of the times, comes to the assistance of His Spouse. Wherefore we believe it to be our duty to avail ourselves the more abundantly of those means which are at our disposal for freeing the Indians from the slavery of Satan and from that of wicked men, inasmuch as the need which afflicts them is the greater. On the other hand, as those lands were by the preachers of the Gospel bedewed not only with their sweat, but also with their blood, we feel confident that from so man>' labors a gladsome harvest of Christian civilization will at length spring up and bear good fruit.

Meanwhile, in order that, through our apostolic authority, the

greatest possible efficacy may attend what you on your own initiative, or through our exhortation, are about to do for the welfare of the Indians, we, following the example of our predecessor already mentioned, condemn and declare guilty of a heinous crime all those, as he says, who "dare or presume to reduce the aforesaid Indians to slavery, to sell them, to buy them, to exchange them or donate them, to separate them from their wives and children, to despoil them of their effects or possessions, to carry or transport them elsewhere, or in any wise to deprive them of their liberty or to hold them as slaves, as well as to give counsel, aid or support under any pretext or plea whatsoever to those who do these things, or to teach and proclaim that all this is lawful, or in any other way to lend their cooperation to what has been stated above." We wish therefore to reserve to the local Ordinaries the power of absolving penitents from such crimes in the sacred tribunal of penance.

These things, venerable brothers, it has seemed good to us to write to you, in the interest of the Indians, both to obey the paternal promptings of our heart and to follow in the wake of so many of our predecessors, amongst whcMn is to be particularly mentioned Leo XIII. of happy memory. It will be for you to strive with all your might that our wishes may be fully realized. You will certainly have as supporters in this work the rulers of those re- publics. Surely the priests, and in the first instance those attadied to the missions, will not fail to assist you by work and advice. In fine, all good people will doubtless assist you ; and whether with money, those who can, or by other efforts of charity, they will favor an enterprise in which are at the same time involved considerations of religion and of human dignity. But what is of chief importance, Almighty God will assist you with His g^ce, as a token of which, and also as a proof of our paternal benevolence, we impart with all our heart to you, venerable brothers, and to your fiocks the Apostolic Benediction.

Given at Rome, at St. Peter's, on the 7th of June, 191 2, in the ninth year of our pontificate.
PIUS X., POPE.

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